PROJECT REPORT OF CO-OP
Project at Industry (Module-2)

ON

Cyber Attack Trends and Sectoral Impact Analysis

submitted in partial fulfilment of the requirements for the award of degree of

BACHELOR OF ENGINEERING
In
COMPUTER SCIENCE AND ENGINEERING

Submitted by:
Nikhil Sharma
Harman Setia
BE22 - CSE

Supervised By:
Prof. Dr. S.B. Goyal
Mentor / Professor
Dept. of CSE, Chitkara University

DEPARTMENT OF COMPUTER SCIENCE AND ENGINEERING
CHITKARA UNIVERSITY INSTITUTE OF ENGINEERING AND TECHNOLOGY
CHITKARA UNIVERSITY, PUNJAB, INDIA

2022 – 2026

DECLARATION

I hereby certify that the work being presented in the project report entitled "Cyber Attack Trends and Sectoral Impact Analysis" in partial fulfilment of requirements for the award of the degree of Bachelor of Engineering (Computer Science and Engineering) submitted in the Department of Computer Science and Engineering at Chitkara University Institute of Engineering and Technology, Chitkara University, Punjab, India, is an authentic record of our own work carried out under the supervision of Prof. Dr. S.B. Goyal. The matter presented in this project report has not been submitted to any other university/institute for the award of any degree.

Place: Rajpura

Date: …….

Nikhil Sharma Harman Setia

This is to certify that the above statement made by the candidates is correct to the best of my knowledge and belief.

(Prof. Dr. S.B. Goyal)
Professor & Mentor
Department of Computer Science and Engineering
Chitkara University Institute of Engineering and Technology
Chitkara University, Punjab, India

ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

We would like to express our deepest gratitude to our mentor, Prof. Dr. S.B. Goyal, Department of Computer Science and Engineering, Chitkara University, for his invaluable guidance, continuous support, and encouragement throughout the course of this project. His expertise in the field of cybersecurity and his constructive feedback greatly helped shape this research.

We are also grateful to the faculty and staff of the Department of Computer Science and Engineering, Chitkara University Institute of Engineering and Technology, for providing us with the resources and environment necessary to undertake this research.

Finally, we would like to thank our families and friends for their unwavering support and motivation throughout this academic journey.

Nikhil Sharma
Harman Setia

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ABSTRACT

With increased digitalization across the globe, susceptibility to cyber-attacks has intensified and is now a major problem for governments, companies, and individuals alike. This study presents a systematic review of well-known cyber-attacks executed over governmental organizations, banks and other financial organizations, the healthcare sector, and other non-governmental organizations. These incidents are analyzed based on frequency distribution across sectors, mode of attack execution, nature and motivation behind actions taken by various kinds of threat actors, as well as overall impact and negative repercussions on operations, financial transactions, and reputation.

Based on reviewed incident reports from 1999 to 2023, a notable increase was observed in the rate and scale of cyber incidents from 2010 onwards. The industries most vulnerable to these attacks include governments, retailers, finance, and healthcare — sectors that hold information of great value and merchandise of significant monetary importance. Data breach incidents are reported on a large scale; however, ransomware and malware attacks were found to be the biggest threats considering their substantial negative impact on economic operations of affected entities. The growing prevalence of nation-states as threat actors has shifted modern cybersecurity toward the geopolitics of cyber operations, transitioning cyber-attacks from common crime to a kind of warfare that can have grave impacts on national economies and national security.

Keywords: Cyber-attacks, Data Breach, Ransomware, Nation-State Actors, Cybersecurity, Threat Analysis, DDoS, Malware

1. INTRODUCTION

The digital age has radically transformed almost every aspect of modern life, enabling greater interconnectedness, communication, and efficiency across all dimensions of society. Today, the majority of entities involved in healthcare, finance, education, retail, and government sectors heavily depend on digital technology to operate, manage vast databases, conduct online transactions, and perform tasks with greater efficacy and speed. Despite the numerous benefits of digital transformation, a myriad of vulnerabilities within digital architecture has also been introduced — vulnerabilities that are prone to exploitation by malevolent individuals and organized groups.

In the early days of the internet era, cyber-attacks were quite rudimentary and may have been limited to activities carried out by a handful of individuals wanting to earn recognition within hacking communities, or occasionally to cause localized destruction. Cyber-attacks during those days required little technical skill and caused only limited damage to isolated systems. The landscape of cyber-attacks, however, has changed dramatically in the past two decades — from being an activity of individuals, it has turned into a full-scale industry operated by highly organized criminal gangs and, increasingly, state-sponsored groups.

With these developments came greater severity in consequences. The damage inflicted through cyber-attacks is reported to amount to several billions of dollars, causing substantial disruption in essential services, large-scale personal data leaks, and direct attacks on national defence capabilities. As widely publicised incidents targeting governments, public infrastructures, hospital networks, and large corporations demonstrate, no institution is left unscathed in the current digital protection landscape. This reality demands updated approaches to cybersecurity — shifting it from a purely technological concern toward a domain of national security and strategic policy.

Another critical dimension of contemporary cybersecurity is the interconnectedness of global systems. Organizations around the globe network together for numerous reasons — shared platforms, cloud services, and supply chains — meaning that an exploit at any one node has the potential to propagate throughout the entire network.

Financial gain remains one of the predominant motivating factors for many attackers, especially organized gangs using ransomware, stealing identities, or selling personal information. However, cyber-attacks can be driven by other motives as well, including political espionage, destabilization of rival states, or ideologically motivated destruction of critical national systems. This variety of motives contributes to an evolving class of operations that can be characterized simultaneously as criminal activity and an act of warfare.

This research aims to study a structured set of major cyber-attacks and investigate underlying patterns across different dimensions: the vulnerabilities of specific industries, the most commonly executed and impactful attack types, profiles of threat actors including their tactics and motivations, and the temporal evolution of cyber-attacks over time.

2. METHODOLOGY

A subset of data collected on major cyber-attacks over the years 1999 to 2023 was utilized for this study. This dataset offers detailed descriptions of each reported attack, enabling the cyber-attacks under examination to be studied in a multifaceted manner.

2.1 Data Description

Each data point in the dataset consists of a set of attributes related to a particular cyber-attack. The variables collected include: the year of the attack; countries targeted; threat actor type (i.e., Nation-state Sponsored or Criminal); the threat actor/group responsible; the type of cyber-attack(s) involved, which include Data Breach, Ransomware, DDoS, Wipers, and others; the industry targeted, including governments, financial services, healthcare systems, or retail; the impact intensity of the attack, classified from Low through to Critical; and the estimated monetary cost of the attack.

2.2 Data Pre-processing

An optimum result was obtained through a formalized data pre-processing stage. Data were cleaned and processed to remove missing entries and to identify and correct inaccuracies and duplicates. Various attributes were normalized for direct comparison. In each case, a cyber-attack recorded against multiple industries or targets was broken down into separate entries for each affected sector.

2.3 Analytical Techniques

The following analytical techniques were applied in this research project:

- Frequency Analysis: Used to identify the target industries being attacked most frequently and to study the relative frequency of targets.
- Time-based Analysis: To evaluate variations in attack frequency and intensity, and to pinpoint critical turning points in the temporal trend.

- Comparative Analysis: To evaluate the relationship between different types of threat actors and types of attacks, and to ascertain the sectors most frequently targeted based on their individual vulnerabilities.
- Impact Assessment: To compare categorical values of the impact of an attack with the determined financial cost of such attacks.

2.4 Limitations of Methodology

Although this dataset provides important insights, there are several limiting features that cannot be ignored. The dataset only includes reported or publicly available attacks from reliable information sources. Less frequently occurring attacks may not be reflected due to being publicly unannounced or intentionally withheld to avoid negative publicity — particularly in cases involving organizations with stronger financial incentives to conceal a breach. Furthermore, the cost of impact varies drastically in terms of reliability; some figures may be based on official reports while others are speculative or entirely absent.

3. TOOLS AND TECHNOLOGIES

The following tools and technologies were employed in the conduct of this research to facilitate data collection, processing, and analysis:

3.1 Data Collection and Management

Microsoft Excel was used for initial data storage, sorting, and filtering of the cyber-attack dataset. The structured spreadsheet format allowed systematic recording of all relevant attributes including year, country, sector, attack type, threat actor, impact level, and monetary cost.

3.2 Data Analysis and Visualization

Python (version 3.x) served as the primary programming language for data analysis. Key libraries employed include Pandas for data manipulation and preprocessing, Matplotlib and Seaborn for data visualization (frequency distributions, temporal trend charts, bar graphs, pie charts), and NumPy for numerical computations.

3.3 Literature Review and Reference Management

Google Scholar, IEEE Xplore, and the ACM Digital Library were used to gather peer-reviewed articles, conference papers, and technical reports related to cybersecurity trends and incident analysis. Reference management was handled using standard citation practices consistent with IEEE format.

3.4 Documentation

Microsoft Word was used for drafting and formatting the project report in accordance with the Chitkara University CO-OP project report template. The research paper was additionally formatted as an IEEE conference-style paper using the appropriate template.

4. IMPLEMENTATION / ANALYSIS

The implementation of this study involved systematic data extraction, cleaning, and analytical processing of the curated cyber-attack dataset spanning 1999 to 2023. The following subsections describe the key stages of the analytical process and the findings observed during each phase.

4.1 Sectoral Distribution of Attacks

The results reveal a clear distribution of attack frequency across sectors. Government systems emerged as the most heavily targeted sector, owing to the large volumes of critical sensitive data they hold — including information related to national security, military operations, diplomatic relations, and personal data of individual citizens. Such information is of significant value to both cybercriminal groups and hostile nations seeking strategic intelligence.

Retail companies were identified as the second most targeted sector. Retailers manage large volumes of credit card numbers, payment information, and financial transaction records — highly saleable commodities in underground markets. The financial sector, including banks, credit institutions, and investment service providers, ranked third due to the easily accessible financial benefits they present to attackers. The healthcare sector ranked fourth, with medical records and personal health information being highly valued on the black market, combined with the critical nature of continuity-of-care services.

4.2 Attack Type Distribution

Data breaches were identified as the most common type of cyber-attack recorded in the dataset. A data breach involves unauthorized access to data, which is then leveraged for further attacks such as identity fraud, financial theft, or sale of information to third parties. The prevalence of data breaches underscores the immense value of data in the modern digital economy.

Ransomware attacks were found to be among the most financially costly types of incidents. These attacks exploit a target's infected data or operating system, demanding a ransom in exchange for restoration — with costs arising not only from the ransom payment but also from

system downtime, repair expenses, and reputational damage. High-profile campaigns against hospitals, municipalities, pipelines, and large enterprises have individually resulted in hundreds of millions of dollars in losses.

Destructive attacks, including wiper malware, represented another significant category. Unlike ransomware, which aims to extract payment, destructive attacks aim to render systems permanently inoperable. These have been executed primarily by nation-state actors as tools of political disruption, targeting rival nations' operational infrastructure. Other notable attack types in the dataset include Distributed Denial of Service (DDoS) attacks and supply chain compromises.

4.3 Threat Actor Profiling

Two primary categories of threat actors were identified. The first consists of criminal individuals and organized groups motivated strictly by financial gain. These range from individual hackers conducting phishing campaigns to sophisticated criminal enterprises operating like legitimate businesses — engaging in ransomware deployments, credential theft, business email compromise (BEC), and sale of stolen data on the dark web.

The second category consists of nation-state actors — groups working under the direction of or with the support of national governments, commanding far greater resources than criminal organizations. Their motivations extend beyond financial gain to encompass espionage, sabotage, and geopolitical destabilization. The most technically advanced and destructive attacks in the dataset are attributable to nation-state actors. It is important to note, however, that the line between criminal and nation-state actors is not always clearly defined, with some criminal elements having documented ties to state-sponsored programs.

4.4 Temporal Analysis

Temporal analysis of the dataset reveals a clear and consistent upward trajectory in both the frequency and severity of cyber-attacks. Prior to 2010, the number of major recorded attacks remained relatively low, though significant incidents were still occurring. Between 2010 and 2022, the number of incidents increased dramatically, with the steepest rise observed between

2016 and 2022 — a period that saw not only the highest number of incidents but also the highest average impact severity.

Contributing factors to this trend include the exponential growth of Internet-connected devices (expanding potential attack surfaces), the rapid adoption of cloud computing and SaaS platforms (introducing new dimensions of vulnerability), the professionalization of cybercrime (lowering barriers to entry for unskilled participants), and an increasing number of governments investing in offensive cyber capabilities.

5. MAJOR FINDINGS / OUTCOMES / RESULTS

The analysis of the dataset yielded several major findings that shed light on the current state and trajectory of the global cyber threat landscape:

5.1 Escalating Frequency and Severity

The study confirms a statistically significant increase in cyber-attack frequency from 2010 onwards, with the 2016–2022 period representing the most intensive phase. Not only did the volume of attacks rise sharply, but the average severity and financial impact per incident also increased substantially during this period.

5.2 High-Value Sectors Face Disproportionate Risk

Government agencies, financial institutions, healthcare providers, and retail organizations collectively accounted for the majority of recorded attacks. These sectors are disproportionately targeted due to the combination of high-value data, critical operational dependencies, and, in some cases, historically underfunded cybersecurity infrastructure.

5.3 Data Breach Dominance

Data breaches emerged as the most frequent attack type across the entire study period. The finding underlines that data — whether personal, financial, intellectual, or operational — has become the primary commodity of the cybercriminal economy. Organizations must recognize that all data they hold, in whatever form, carries significant value and must be protected accordingly.

5.4 Ransomware and Destructive Malware as Leading Cost Drivers

While less frequent than data breaches, ransomware and wiper malware attacks consistently generated the highest monetary and operational damage. A small number of extremely large-scale incidents were found to account for the majority of total financial losses across the study period, illustrating the asymmetric nature of cybersecurity risk.

5.5 Geopoliticization of Cyber Threats

The increasing involvement of nation-states in cyber operations represents a paradigm shift in the threat landscape. Attacks are no longer purely criminal in nature — they increasingly serve as instruments of geopolitical competition, espionage, and hybrid warfare. This trend has elevated cybersecurity to the level of a national security concern.

5.6 Need for International Cooperation

The analysis demonstrates that cyber-attacks frequently transcend national borders, targeting multiple countries simultaneously. Effective response and deterrence require robust international cooperation — including intelligence-sharing channels, harmonized cybersecurity standards, and mechanisms for holding state-level actors accountable.

6. CONCLUSION AND FUTURE SCOPE

6.1 Conclusion

The analysis performed in this study confirms a significant increase in both the frequency and intensity of cyber-attacks over the period 1999 to 2023, with the most dramatic escalation occurring between 2016 and 2022. Government agencies, financial institutions, retail businesses, and healthcare providers remain disproportionately targeted, though the data confirms that cyber risk has become a universal concern affecting virtually every sector of the modern digital economy.

Data breaches represent the most common form of cyber-attack during the study period, driven by the immense value of data in today's economy. Ransomware and destructive malware attacks, while less frequent, produce the greatest operational and financial damage. The increasing involvement of nation-states as threat actors has fundamentally shifted the nature of cybersecurity — from a matter of organizational IT management to a domain of national security and geopolitical strategy.

Organizations across all sectors must begin treating cybersecurity as a core business priority. Effective security programs must include continuous monitoring, regular vulnerability assessments, investment in advanced defence technologies, and comprehensive incident response and recovery plans. Employee training remains critical, as human error continues to be a primary entry point for many of the most devastating attacks.

Governments must enhance cooperation at the national and international level to address transborder cyber threats — establishing channels for intelligence sharing, harmonizing cybersecurity standards, and developing accountability mechanisms for state-sponsored attacks. The security challenges of the 21st century are inherently collaborative in nature, and no single organization or nation can address them in isolation.

6.2 Future Scope

Future research could extend this study in several important directions. First, the dataset could be expanded to include more recent incidents (2024 onwards) as well as attacks that are currently underreported due to non-disclosure practices, providing a more comprehensive view of the threat landscape. Second, machine learning and artificial intelligence techniques could be applied to the dataset to develop predictive models for identifying likely attack targets, estimating potential impacts, and detecting emerging attack patterns before they become widespread.

Third, future work could explore the intersection of emerging technologies — including 5G infrastructure, the Internet of Things (IoT), and AI-powered systems — with cyber vulnerability, as these represent rapidly expanding attack surfaces. Finally, a more granular analysis of the legal, regulatory, and policy responses to major cyber incidents across different countries could yield actionable insights for policymakers and governance bodies working to strengthen national and international cyber resilience.

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